

- 3) State the concept of action research coined by Kurt Lewin.

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- 4) Do you think that action research play a catalysist role? Give reasons for your answer in two sentences.

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20.4 PRINCIPLES OF ACTION RESEARCH

A set of six principles according to winter guide an action research. These principles are discussed below:

1) **Reflective Critical Analysis**

It is the process of becoming aware of our own perceptual biases. For example, description or narration of a situation in any notes, transcripts, or official documents imply that it is factional and true. It claims to be reliable and authentic. But truth in any social setting or social reality is in relative to the teller. The principle of reflective critical analysis ensures people to reflect on issues and practices and make explicit interpretations, biases, assumptions and concern upon which judgments are made. In this way, practical description can give rise to theoretical considerations.

2) **Dialectical Critical Analysis**

It is a way of understanding the relationships between the elements that make up various phenomena in our context. Social reality is validated or shared through language. Phenomena are conceptualized in dialogue. Therefore a dialectical critical analysis is required to understand a set of relationship both between the phenomenon and its context, and between the elements constituting the phenomenon. The important point is to focus attention on those constituent elements that are unstable or opposing one another simply because these elements are most likely to create changes.

3) **Collaborative Resource**

The principles of collaborative resources presuppose that each person's ideas are equally significant as potential resources for creating interpretive categories of analysis, which are negotiated among the participants. It makes possible the insight gathered between many viewpoint and within a single viewpoint. Hence everyone's view is taken as a contribution to understand the situation. Participants in action research are co-researchers.

4) **Risk**

It is an understanding of our own taken-for-granted processes and willingness to submit them to critique. Normally, the change process is considered a threat to all previously established ways of doing things, thus creating

psychiatric fears among the participants. One of the most prominent fears emanates from the risk of ego generation from open discussion of one's interpretations, ideas and judgment. Initiator of action research will use this principle to reduce other's fears and invite participation by assuring that they, too, will be the subject to the same process and that whatever be the outcome, learning will take place.

5) Plural Structure

It involves developing various accounts and critiques, rather than a single authoritative interpretation. The action research comprises of a multiplicity of views, Commentaries and critical analysis which lead to multiple possible actions and interpretation. This inquiry requires much texts for reporting. Thus, there will be many explanations made clear and range of options for action presented. A report, therefore, acts as a support for ongoing discussion among collaborators rather than a final conclusion of fact.

6) Theory, Practice and Transformation

Theory and practice are considered two inter-dependent yet complementary phases of the change process. For action researchers, theory informs practice and practice refines theory in a continuous transformation. In any setting, people's actions are based on implicitly held assumptions, theories and hypotheses. With every observed result, theoretical knowledge is enhanced. Thus, a single change process has two intertwined aspects. It is up to the researchers to make the theoretical justifications explicit for action, and to question the basis of that justification. The ensuring practical applications as a follow up are subjected to further analysis in five cycles that continuously alternates emphasis between theory and practice.

20.5 CHARACTERISTICS OF ACTION RESEARCH

Action research has the following characteristics:

- 1) **It is collaborative, i.e.** everyone's view is taken as a contribution in understanding the situation. Moreover, if a problem is faced by a practitioner in a particular situation (say a school), action research can be collaborative where practitioners facing similar problems in nearby schools can collaborate to find solutions of a problem.
- 2) **Action research helps in systems planning and restructuring.** For example, if a primary teacher finds that in his/her class the students are not able to concentrate, the teacher starts finding the reasons for the same. After analyzing the situation, the teacher finds that most of the children often observe other children playing in the playground because of opening of classroom window towards playground. They, therefore, are not able to concentrate in their studies in the class. Now, what do you think a teacher should do? Well, in such a case a teacher can change the seating plan of the classroom. This is the way a teacher gets involved in restructuring the class.
- 3) **Action research is a small-scale intervention.** Its objective is to bring out changes in the functioning of the practitioner himself/herself. It may or may not have applicability for others. Action research is a narrowly focused research undertaken by teachers and other practitioners in a given specific situation and context.

- 4) **Contextual nature** is an important characteristics of action research. For example, a teacher of a particular school may face a particular problem in the form of errors committed by fifth grade students in English comprehension in a school but the same problem may not be observed by him/her in other schools.
- 5) **It enhances the *competencies of the practitioners***. Action research enables practitioners to have a clear vision of the problematic situation. This becomes helpful in identifying ways and means to tackle the problem.
- 6) **Action research seeks to *improve the quality of human relationships***.
- 7) **Action research seeks to understand particular complex** social situations whether it is a class, school or community.
- 8) **Action research allows us to identify remedial measures for improvement**. It is specific in nature, i.e. specific to a particular class, school or situation. Therefore, results cannot be generalized.
- 9) ***It is a systematic and scientific process*** but not very rigorous.
- 10) Action research is *participatory*: it is research through which people work towards the improvement of *their own practices*.
- 11) Action research makes use of quantitative and qualitative methodologies.
- 12) Action research is open-minded about what counts as evidence (or data) – it involves not only *keeping records* which describe what is happening as accurately as possible . . . but also *collecting and analysing our own judgements, reactions and impressions* about what is going on.
- 13) Action research is a *political process* because it involves us in making changes that will affect others.
- 14) It is a *systematic learning process* wherein people act deliberately, but remaining open to surprises and responsive to opportunities.
- 15) Action research allows us to build *records* of our improvements and changing *activities and practices*. It records the changes in the *language and discourse* we describe, explain and justify our practices. It also documents changes in the *social relationships and forms of organization* which characterize and constrain our practices.

20.6 MODELS OF ACTION RESEARCH

Numerous authors and researchers have proposed models for undertaking the action research. Because the process involved in action research is somewhat dynamic, various models look a bit different from one another but possess numerous common elements. Starting with a central problem or topic, action research models involve some observation or monitoring of current practice, followed by the collection and synthesis of information and data. Finally, some sort of action is taken, which serves as the basis for next stage of action research. Some models are simple in their design, while others appear relatively complex. Let us discuss some models of action research as an illustration.

20.6.1 Kemmis and McTaggart's Spiral Model

These two authors describe this model as participatory research. In this model, action research involves a spiral of self-reflective cycles of:

- Planning a change.
- Acting and observing the process and consequences of the change.
- Reflecting on these processes and consequences and then re-planning.
- Acting and observing.
- Reflecting, etc.

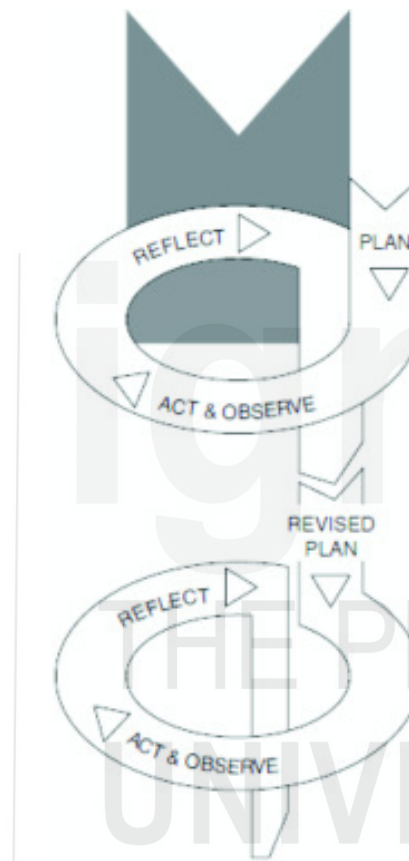


Fig. 20.1: Kemmis and McTaggart's Action Research Spiral

Kemmis and McTaggart's (2000) do not recommend to use it as a rigid structure. They maintain that in reality the process may not be as neat as the spiral of self-contained cycles of planning, acting, observing, and reflecting suggests. These stages, they maintain, will *overlap*, and initial plans will quickly become obsolete in the light of learning from experience. In reality the process is likely to be more fluid, open, and responsive.

We find the spiral model appealing because it gives an opportunity to visit a phenomenon at a higher level each time and so to progress towards a greater overall understanding. By carrying out action research using this model, you can understand a particular issue within a healthcare context and make informed decisions with an enhanced understanding. It is therefore about empowerment. However, Winter and Munn-Giddings (2001) point out that the spiral model may suggest that even the basic process may take a long time to complete.

The model employed by Elliot (1991) shares many of the features of that of Kemmis and McTaggart and is based on Lewin's work of the 1940s. It includes identifying a general idea, reconnaissance or fact-finding, planning, action, evaluation, amending plan and taking second action step, and so on, as can be seen in Figure 20.2.

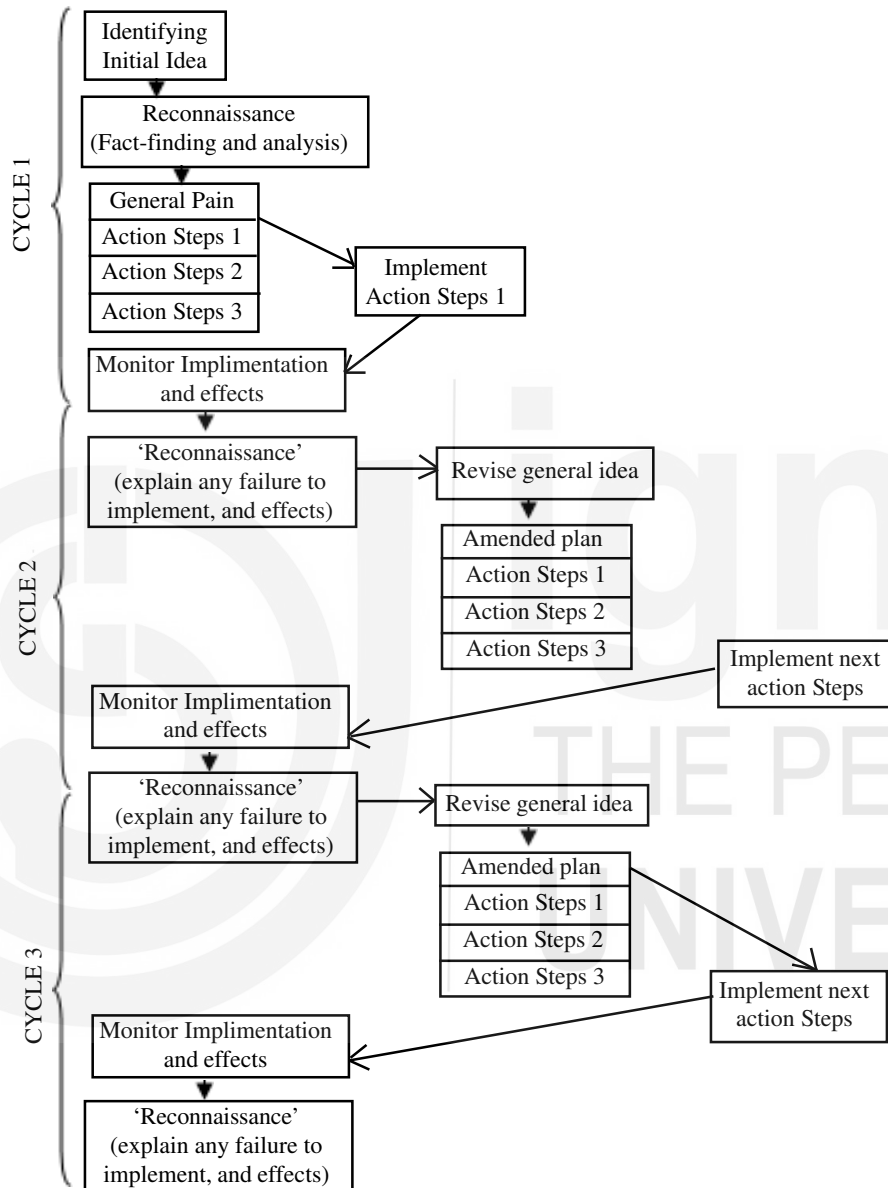


Fig. 20.2: Elliot's Action Research Model

Source: Elliot, J. Action Research for Educational Change

20.6.3 O'Leary's Cycles of Action Research Model

Cycles of action research shown in Figure 20.3, portray action research as a cyclic process which takes shape as knowledge emerges. In this model, it is stressed that 'cycles converge towards better understanding of situation and improved action implementation. Cycle of actions are based in evaluative practice that alters between action and critical reflection'. O'Leary sees action research as an experiential learning approach to change, where the goal is to continually

refine the methods, data, and interpretation in the light of understanding developed in each earlier cycle.

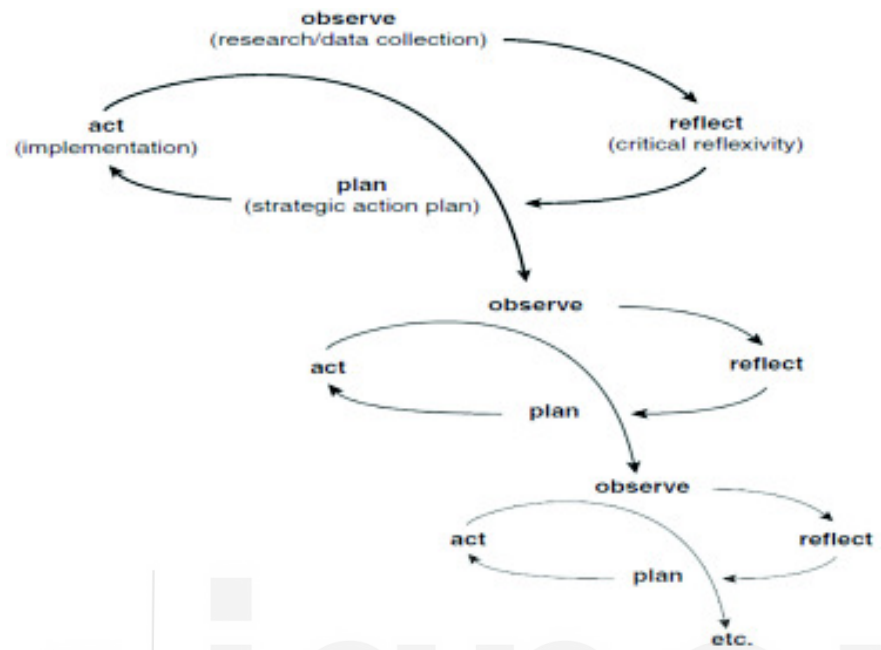


Fig. 20.3: O'Leary's Cycles of Research

20.6.4 Stringer's Interacting Spiral Action Research Model

"Simple, yet powerful framework" consisting of a "look, think, and act" routine. During each stage, participants observe, reflect, and then take some sort of action. This action leads them into the next stage (see Figure 20.4).

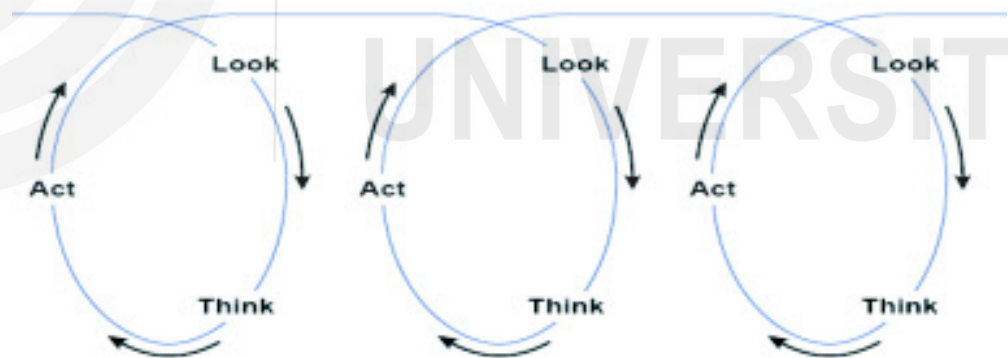


Fig. 20.4: Stringer's Interacting Spiral Action Research Model

20.6.5 Kurt Lewin's Action Research Spiral Model

Stringer propounded interacting spiral model and viewed that "action research"—also depicts an action research spiral, which includes fact finding, planning, taking action, evaluating, and amending the plan, before moving into a second action step (see Figure 20.5)

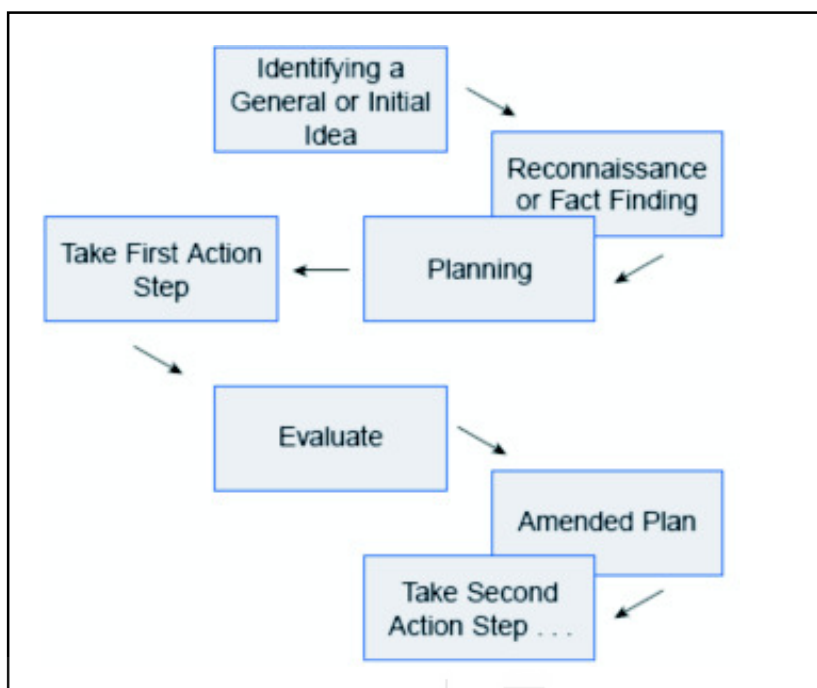


Fig. 20.5: Lewin's Action Research Spiral

Source: Adapted from *Encyclopedia of Informal Education*. (www.infed.org).

20.6.6 Calhoun's Action Research Cycle Model

While not appearing as a “spiral,” still represents a process that is built around a cyclical notion. As she describes, the solid lines indicate the primary direction of the action research cycle through the phases in numerical order. The dotted lines indicate backward and forward movement within the cycle as refinement or clarification of information is warranted (see Figure 20.6).

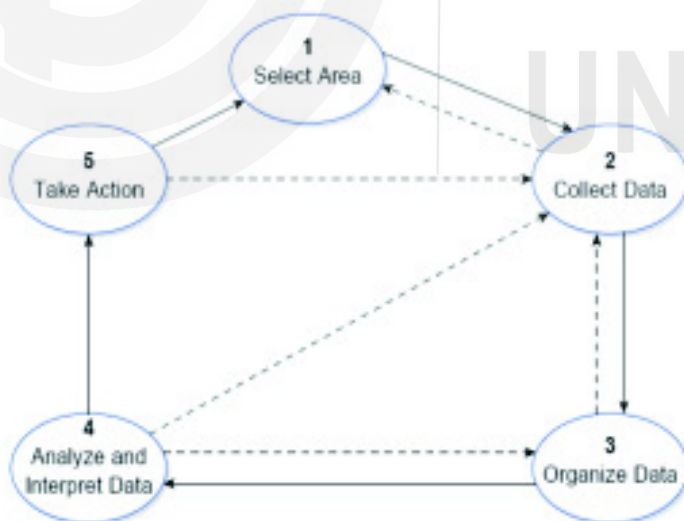


Fig. 20.6: Calhoun's Action Research Cycle

20.6.7 Bachman's Action Research Spiral Model

Action research spiral continues this notion of the cyclical nature of action research (see Figure 20.7). His downward spiral suggests that participants gather information, plan actions, observe and evaluate those actions, and then reflect and plan for a new cycle of the spiral, based on the insights that were gained in the previous cycle.

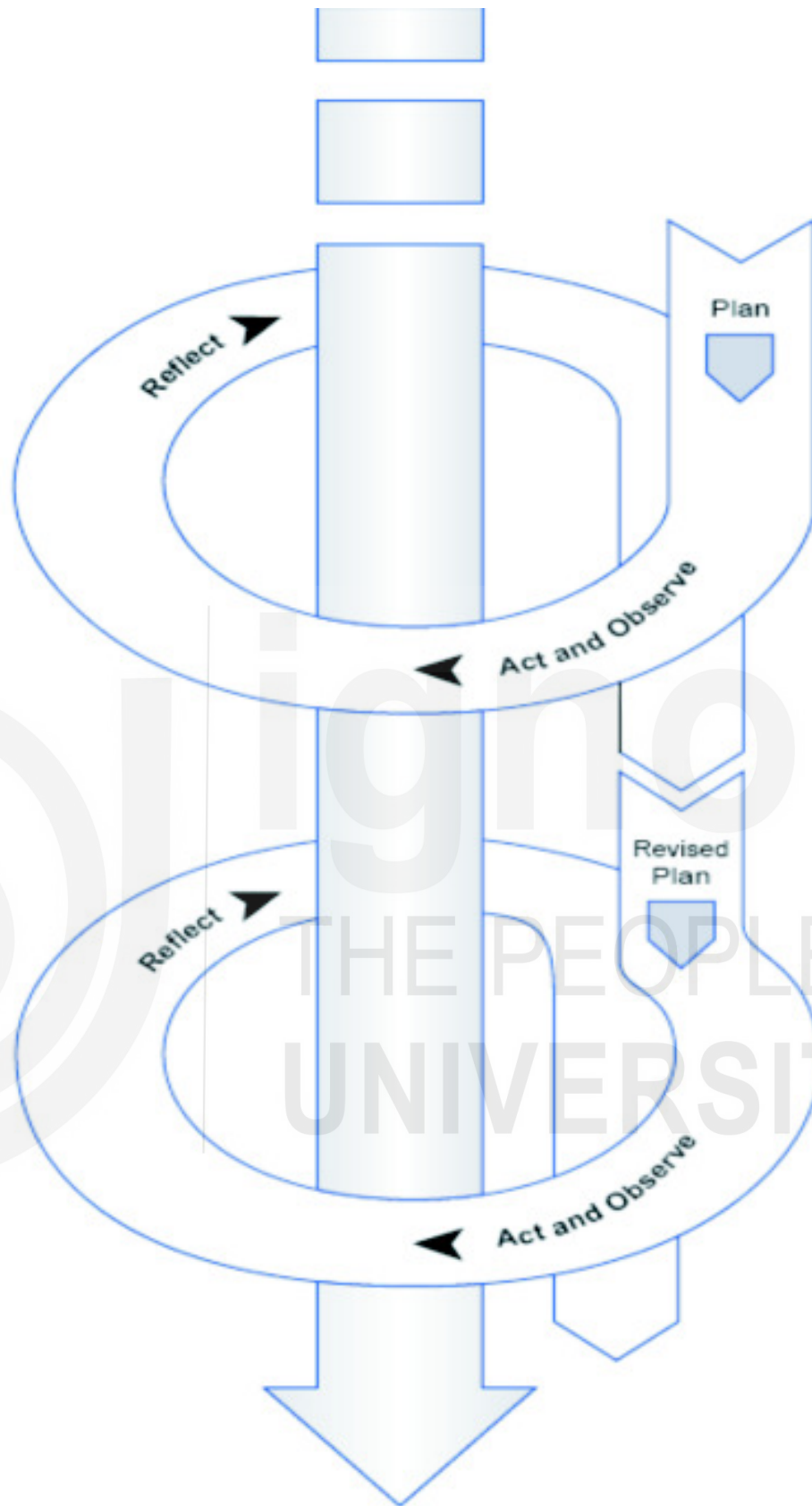
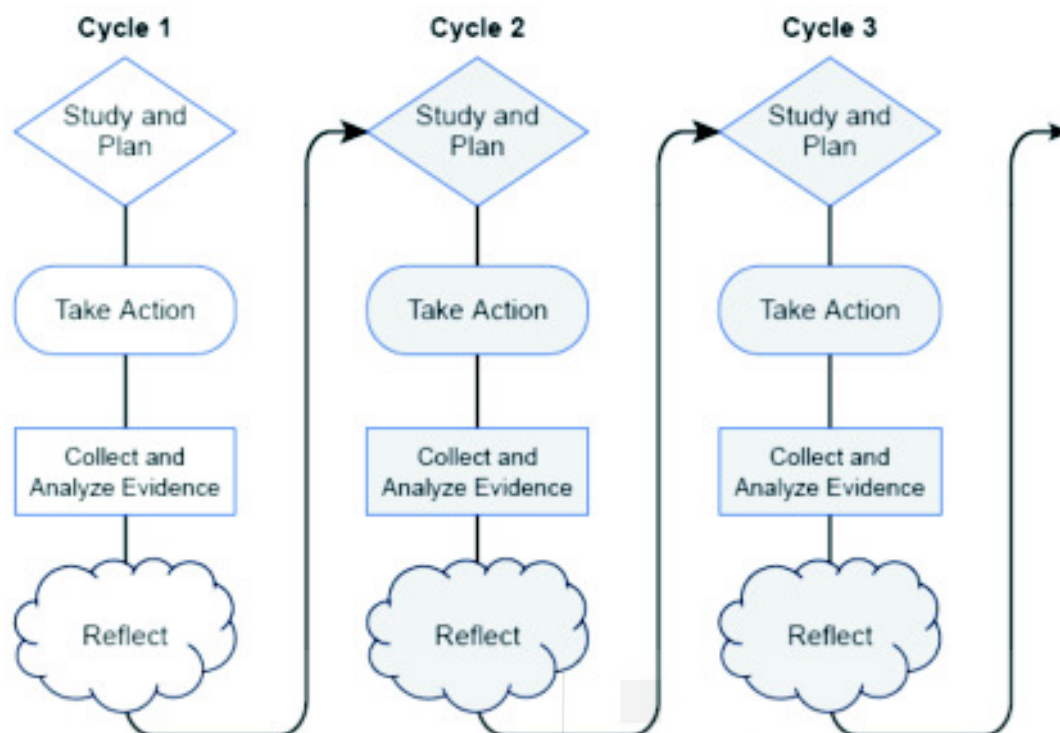


Fig. 20.7: Bachman's Action Research Spiral Model

20.6.8 Riel's Progressive Problem Solving Model

Through action research model takes the participants through four steps in each cycle: planning, taking action, collecting evidence, and reflecting (see Figure 20.8).



Progressive Problem Solving With Action Research

Fig. 20.8: Riel's Action Research Model

20.6.9 Hendricks's Action Research Model

It is shown in Figure 20.9. In her model, which she has placed in a school-based context, focuses on acting, evaluating, and reflecting.



Fig. 20.9: Hendricks's Action Research Process

Source: Adapted from *Improving Schools Through Action Research: A Comprehensive Guide for Educators*, by Cher Hendricks, 2009, Boston: Allyn & Bacon.

From the above different models of action research, it can be inferred that the following four stages are essential features of the model. However, this does not mean that this is how all action research projects will work. The flexibility of action research based on constant evaluation and reflection means that the cycles may be truncated as new ways to proceed further.

i) **Planning**

Identifying the issue to be changed looking elsewhere for information. Similar projects may be useful, for developing the questions and research methods to be used to develop a plan related to the specific environment. In the school setting this could involve personnel, budgets and the use of outside agencies.

ii) **Acting**

Trialling the change following your plan, collecting and compiling evidence, questioning the process and making changes as required.

iii) **Observing**

Analysing the evidence and collating the findings, discussing the findings with co-researchers and /or colleagues for interpretation, writing the report, sharing your findings with stakeholders and peers.

iv) **Reflecting**

Evaluating the first cycle of the process, implementing the findings or new strategy, revisiting the process.

These features might be represented diagrammatically as given below



Fig. 20.10

While working through action research remember that:

- It is cyclical and progress is made in small chunks,
- It is heavily based on critical reflection you can use.